

8.2 Opening files:

Before beginning to work with a file, it is indispensable to know how to open it for different purposes. This includes reading, writing or sometimes both. PHP has the 'fopen()' function for this purpose. The function used for opening a file should include a string that contains a file path. It should also include another string with the mode in which the file is expected to be opened.

Some of the common modes used in the function for opening a file include read ('r'), write ('w'), and append ('a'). Certain special functions are applied to open files for different purposes. The following examples would provide the clear idea:

- File to open for reading: \$fp = fopen("XYZ.txt", 'r');
- File to open for writing: \$fp = fopen(" XYZ.txt", 'w');
- File to open for appending: \$fp = fopen(" XYZ.txt", 'a');

If the file fails to open for any reason the function fopen() returns false, generating a message. The following example illustrates this point.

```
<html>
<body>
<?php
$file_ptr = fopen("welcomefile.txt","r") or
exit("Unable to open file!");
?>
</body>
</html>
```

As we have seen earlier, there are three standard methods of opening a file in PHP. However, there are certain other methods, also, through which you can open a file so that both reading and writing can easily be done. This is possible by inserting a plus symbol (+) after the file mode.

To open a file, both for reading and writing `r+` (the file pointer should be at the beginning of the file)

To delete all information from the file when the file is opened `w+` (the file pointer should be at the beginning of the file)

To append `a+` (the file pointer should be at the end of the file)